

Periodontal conditions in vegetarians: a clinical study.



BACKGROUND/OBJECTIVES: Investigations about possible correlations between vegetarian diet and periodontal conditions are rare and characterized by small case numbers. The aim of this clinical study was to investigate the influence of a vegetarian diet on periodontal parameters with an appropriate sample size. SUBJECTS/METHODS: A total of 200 patients, 100 vegetarians and 100 non-vegetarians, were included in the study. All patients were examined including a full mouth assessment of the periodontal and dental conditions. In addition, a questionnaire was handed out to ask for patients' oral hygiene habits and level of education. For statistical analysis the Mann-Whitney Test (χ^2) for analysis of the questionnaire) was applied (level of significance: $P < 0.05$). RESULTS: Well known periodontal risk factors like age, gender and smoking habits were equally distributed within each group (71 females, 29 males, respectively and 10 smokers in each group; mean age: 41.45 years vegetarians versus 41.72 years non-vegetarians). Vegetarians had significantly lower probing pocket depths ($P = 0.039$), bleeding on probing ($P = 0.001$), periodontal screening index ($P = 0.012$), a better hygiene index ($P < 0.001$) and less mobile teeth ($P = 0.013$). Dental examinations revealed significantly less missing teeth ($P = 0.018$) but also more decayed ($P = 0.001$) and eroded ($P = 0.026$) teeth in vegetarians. Furthermore, vegetarians had a higher level of education ($P < 0.001$), but visited dentists significantly less frequent. CONCLUSIONS: Vegetarians revealed better periodontal conditions (less inflammation signs, less periodontal damage and a better dental home care). However, it should be considered that vegetarians are not only avoiding meat in their nutrition but are also characterized by an overall healthier life style.